them best organize to increase their voice, gain greater autonomy, and create opportunities to influence others. Third, this book shows that the BRICS have evolved a dual strategy that recognizes the benefits of reforming incumbent Bretton Woods institutions from within, while simultaneously developing outside options to create parallel institutions to promote their collective interests. Here, China's emergence as a major power presents the BRICS, on the one hand, with greater bargaining power and international opportunities than the other four possess, either individually or collectively, in the area of financial statecraft. On the other hand, China's rising economic and financial power introduces the unavoidable domination of China's preferences that may come to overshadow the others. This relationship raises questions about the credibility and durability of China's commitment to collective purposes and the extent to which the other BRICS can harness China's strengths to their advantage while containing the risks of exploitation.

STRATEGIC INCENTIVES IN UNIPOLARITY AND COMMON AVERSIONS

The BRICS emerged in the unipolar era, after the collapse of the Soviet Union in the early 1990s, when the United States possessed unparalleled structural power in the modern international system by virtue of its immense capabilities, from the dominance of the dollar to global military reach.[20] American leaders embraced the "triumph of liberalism" and the unipolar system after the collapse of the Soviet Union, where a stronger, more stable structure than regional hegemony in the Western world was expected to coalesce around U.S. dominance.[21] Although the U.S.-led liberal order offers many advantages to emerging economies, these countries are aware of Washington's strategy to maintain its superior position by actively deterring peer competitors and coopting potential opponents. Such unipolar power incentives have encouraged the BRICS to support a return to multipolarity. Yet each still recognizes the United States as the world's superpower, and all have been disincentivized by unipolarity to form an alliance to balance against the United States.

The absence of "hard" (i.e., military) balancing against the United States thus flows from the similar strategic incentives that the BRICS countries face. Shared values in human rights or democracy of some BRICS members did not make them behave differently from other members with less